

Photographs by A. PRASHANKAR RAO



OPEN FIRE: Rathore ignites the canon

failed to catch the fancy of the local crowds of Hyderabad.

There were four helicopters hovering over the venue and the National Security Guards posted on rooftops to handle the security from the air for the opening and the closing ceremonies.

As expected, the men in uniform and their families were the most conspicuous attendees. But entry for all others was restricted unless they carried specially-issued entry passes that were distributed through select branches of the Canara Bank. As rifle-toting soldiers stood outside the venues to restrict access, the primary aim of promoting peace and friendship through sport was overshadowed by heavy machinery.

These restrictions at such a large sports event were uncalled for. By no means were the competitors vulnerable: it is estimated that for every competitor there were eight other people around him or her, either involved in organising the event or on security duty.

Amongst the athletes at MWG were five medal winners from the 2004 Athens Olympics. But there was little effort to spread awareness about the presence of these Olympians, and an even smaller chance for the average spectator to catch them in action.

There was a marked reluctance on the part of the organisers to share information which threw even television commentators into a tizzy. "Given

MILITARY IMPRECISION

- Ordinary fans cut off from entry to most sports stadia.
- The presence of five Olympic medallists was under-publicised.
- Oppressive security stopped athletes from venturing outdoors.
- There was lack of a streamlined information system for outsiders.



BEST FOOT FORWARD: Women soldiers during the Games parade

their inherent nature and mindset, the army generals were insular to advice too," says an Andhra Pradesh official involved with the organising of the Games.

The security blanket covered all at the MWG, including the visiting contingents. Soldiers from nations that took part in the US-led war on Iraq were given special security cover. They were told not to venture outdoors to shop or do sightseeing as the US army officials were apprehensive of attacks from terror groups.

The Military World Games began in 1995 to mark half a century of the end of the World War II, the idea being to encourage armed forces to meet in sports arenas rather than on battlefield. But the impact of realpolitik is never far and in the case of Hyderabad, Pakistan refused to play ball. It made a conscientious presence at MWG attending the first three editions of the event at Rome (1995), Zagreb (1999) and Catania (2003). But making the trip to the land of their bitter adversaries for a series of sports events, that too involving the military, was deemed inappropriate. CISM Chairman Gianni Gola admits, "It was a big mistake. We tried our best to convince Pakistan's military authorities to follow the example set by the civilian sports bodies of India and Pakistan, but we did not succeed. They have missed a splendid opportunity." CISM has since rejected Pakistan's offer to host its general assembly meeting in 2009.

The growing stature of MWG can be gauged from the weight IOC has thrown behind it. IOC offered 60,000 euros to pay for the travel expenses of the teams which could not afford to travel to Hyderabad. It actually helped many poor African nations field their contingents. Brazil, which is to host the 2011 MWG, brought contingents from four other South American countries on its plane. India also sent a plane to ferry a contingent of 32, including a soccer team of war-torn Afghanistan, first-time MWG competitors.

From the thousands of competitors at MWG could have come a thousand stirring tales. Pity then that the organisers first announced a carnival and then did their best to put up what amounted to a tightly closed shop. ■